

Storytelling

Frame the user's problem as a narrative to build empathy and buy-in

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Design storytelling casts research findings and concepts as a narrative — a protagonist (the user), a tension (their unmet need) and a resolution (the design). Narrative makes abstract insight vivid, memorable and persuasive to stakeholders and teammates alike.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

A cross-disciplinary practice; foregrounded in design thinking by IDEO and in the *Design Thinking Toolbox*.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Data and bullet points rarely move decision-makers. Stories create emotional connection and shared understanding, aligning teams and winning support for user-centred choices.

HOW IT IS USED

Structure the insight as a short arc — who, what they struggle with, what changes — and deliver it through the user's voice, artefacts or a scenario rather than a slide of facts.

WHEN IT IS USED

Communicating research, pitching concepts and building buy-in across the process.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Designers, product managers, founders and change leaders.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It weaponises **narrative for empathy and persuasion**, ensuring insights survive the journey from research to decision.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Point of View (PoV) *Slibrary 6*

Persona / User Profile *Slibrary 5*

Customer Journey Map *Slibrary 5*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.

Denning, S. (2005) *The Leader's Guide to Storytelling*. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass.

FIGURE 1 · THE NARRATIVE ARC

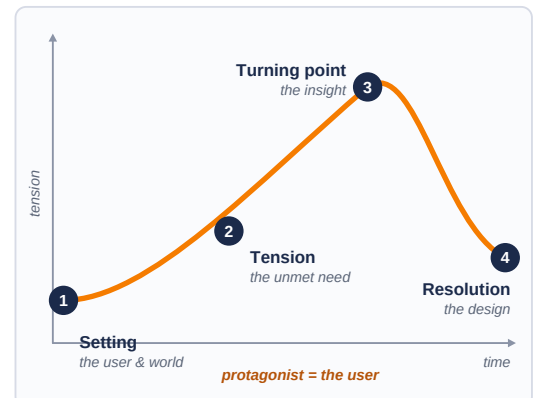


Figure 1. Research told as a story: a protagonist, rising tension around the need, an insight, and the design as resolution.